India's political system. Southeast and Northeast Asians are not attracted to it and hold India's politics responsible for the country's policy incoherence, governance ineffectiveness, and stuttering economic growth and backwardness.

Second, since 2014, particularly in the eyes of the West, India's claim to political openness is increasingly under question. If Western critics are right, India's lead in the one soft power dimension where it did better is eroding. Indeed, to the extent that India is becoming politically more centralized and less democratic, it appears to be moving in the direction of the Chinese model. India's liberal decline suggests that in the contest over political values it is China that may prevail. Indians may choose to be governed more like China rather than the other way round. If so, China will have swept the soft power contest altogether.

Most observers of international relations would say that India does not, and at least in the foreseeable future cannot, match China's soft power. The narrative around China's rise is a global one. Any mention of China usually evokes a conversation about its size, astonishing economic and military rise, ubiquitous presence in the global marketplace, the burgeoning and modernity of its cities and infrastructure, the ambition and energy of its people, the far-seeing and technocratic abilities of its leadership at many levels (not just at the very top), the single-minded pursuit of power and influence, its dedicated long-term strategic vision, the magnificence of its classical culture and heritage, and the driving spirit of its contemporary culture. Virtually all discussions of China in other words exhibit a sense of awe and fascination. Few would choose to describe India in the same way.

Even Indians who read about China or have visited the country, no matter how patriotic, develop that sense of awe and fascination, and feel deflated about India. Years ago, a hard-nosed Indian diplomat friend was invited to China under a Sino-Indian agreement. Before he left, he was studiously blasé. He had, he said, read all the stories and seen all the shiny pictures of the new China, especially its cities and special economic zones. He was prepared to be underwhelmed or at least not terribly surprised. We met soon after he returned. He now confessed to being 'blown away' (or